which began with a global tour kickstarting in India. The kind of binding glue that Indian music has keeps me in continued awe of it. It makes all of us want to push beyond existing boundaries into new musical landscapes. That is the power and strength of Shakti."

This Moment is Shakti's first new studio album in over 45 years. Ask the members whether they plan to work on more albums soon and Hussain is quick to interrupt: "There is nothing without music, without harmony. The fact that we are able to make this kind of music is because we have our independent journeys too. What is significant is how rich and layered these journeys make the work we do together. It also gives me personally an opportunity to constantly keep learning from everyone that brings their emotions and experiences when we jam together. It keeps me on my toes!"

Hussain is forever on his toes—jetting from one part of the world to another, making music sans barriers. Whilst being in the middle of a global tour, the maestro is gearing up to collaborate with the Symphony Orchestra of India for a triple concerto that will be held at the National Centre for Performing Arts (NCPA) soon, which will see him alongside Chaurasia and sitar player Niladri Kumar. "I have seen my father trying to hone his skills even when he was 76! Seeing that addiction inspired me. And also because the tabla keeps me energised and fuelled up," says Hussain. ■

–Aarti Kapur Singh

THEATRE

EPIC ROCK



Lillete Dubey's *Jaya! The Victory!* is a rock musical based on the Mahabharata

Despite the ubiquity of music in Indian life, and a rich heritage of music in drama, contemporary Indian theatre has staged few home-grown musicals; even fewer with an English libretto. Among those very few was Lillete Dubey's 1990s production of Sandeep Kanjilal's retelling of the Mahabharata, *Jaya! The Victory!* It ran for 40 shows before it closed. And in the months of putting it together, "I must have aged two years," says Dubey over the phone, on the way to rehearsals of her current production of... the same play.

Bringing *Jaya* back isn't a recent impulse, she says; she had got permission from Kanjilal's daughters as far back as 2013, and plans to do it in 2016 (Primetime Theatre's 25th anniversary) and 2021 had had to be shelved.

This revival is, in one way, more complex. Kanjilal—who had not just written the words for the earlier production, but was also composer, music director and vocal director—passed away in 2003, and the only soundtrack Dubey still had from that time was not of high quality. So she decided to start almost from scratch and bring in a composer to write a new score. No mean task, because it is a story entirely told in song: that is, two hours of continuous music, but Ashutosh Pathak has delivered, she says.

The music is various sub-genres of rock, and so getting the right singers was key. (Like many other directors, she agrees that it is easier to train a singer to act than it is to train an actor to sing.) And there was movement to be choreographed—Kalaripayattu is used in the martial sequences, and Kathak is in the mix as well—and costumes and sets.

DUBEY HAD GOT PERMISSION FROM KANJILAL'S DAUGHTERS AS FAR BACK AS 2013, AND PLANS TO DO *JAYA* IN 2016 AND 2021 HAD HAD TO BE SHELVED

Jaya, she says, is "a glimpse of this amazing epic which works on so many levels". Instead of the many layers of the complex work, "we stayed with the spine of the story, starting with Yudhishthira at the end of his life looking back at the key events that led to Kurukshetra, what were the learnings, what sort of victory was it really." 'The Victory', she says, is a slightly ironic title, considering the devastation it left in its wake. "And I find it so strange that, as I'm doing it, I'm constantly thinking, my God, what a sad statement that, after so many millennia, nothing has changed. I mean there is Palestine and Israel, there is Ukraine and Russia, and man's desire—and I mean *man's* desire—for power and greed is unabated."

In a time when offence is easily, and often, taken, is there worry about guardians of culture questioning the retelling of one of the most important texts of contemporary Hinduism? "For one, it is my text—I'm Hindu. It is a beautiful rendering for a young generation who don't know 90 per cent of it, except that it has a very 'now' kind of sound, and it's in English. And you have the beautiful core of the Gita."

The team has done their duty to the best of their ability, and the rewards, as the sacred text says, are up to the universe, in the form of the audiences. ■

–Peter Griffin



NATASHA HEMRAJANI

A scene from *Jaya! The Victory!*

The Primetime Theatre Co.'s **Jaya! The Victory!** *opens February 10, at Bal Gandharva Rangmandir, Bandra, Mumbai, with more shows on 11th, and 15th to 18th*